



British men line up outside the recruitment office in Southwark Town Hall, London. Thousands of men from all sections of society volunteered for army service.

“THE PLUNGE OF CIVILIZATION INTO THIS ABYSS OF BLOOD AND DARKNESS... IS TOO TRAGIC FOR ANY WORDS.”

Henry James, American author, August 4, 1914

In continental Europe, millions of men were called up and dispatched by train to the frontiers, while a much smaller force of British regular soldiers was sent to France as the **British Expeditionary Force (BEF)**. Lord Kitchener (1850–1916), the British secretary for war, launched a drive to recruit volunteers. The response was overwhelming, with three-quarters of a million British men enlisted by the end of September. Most people expected a short war with high casualties, and at first this expectation seemed justified.

German troops surged into Belgium, adopting an official policy of “Schrecklichkeit” (frightfulness). They committed atrocities against the Belgian population—in the worst incident 674 civilians were massacred at Dinant—and laid waste the historic city of Louvain, burning its famous university library.

The BEF experienced its first action at Mons. Unable to resist the German onslaught, the British and French were driven back toward Paris. Meanwhile, the



GERMAN INVASION OF FRANCE

The German war plan, devised in 1906 by then chief of staff Count Alfred von Schlieffen, assumed that, if attacked on two fronts, France would concentrate its forces along its eastern border. The bulk of the German army was to advance through Belgium and Luxembourg, encircling the French armies. The aim was to defeat the French in six weeks, before the Russians could enter the fray.

French launched their own offensive along the eastern French–German border, but they suffered heavy losses for no gain. By the beginning of September the situation was desperate for

the British and French armies. The Germans were also forced to change their tactics, abandoning their plan to advance to the west of Paris, and instead marching to the east of the city. French army commander General Joseph Joffre (1852–1931) launched a counteroffensive at the Marne, while troops from Paris—some of whom were carried to the front in buses and taxis—attacked the German flank. The German army

Refugees flee Belgium

Roads in Belgium were lined with refugees like these, carrying whatever possessions they could, and fleeing from the advancing German army.



250,000 THE TOTAL NUMBER OF BRITISH, FRENCH, AND GERMAN CASUALTIES AT THE FIRST BATTLE OF YPRES

was forced to retreat, their hopes of a swift victory in ruins.

On the Eastern Front the Russians mobilized more quickly than Germany had anticipated, but as they advanced into East Prussia the Russian First and Second Armies were crushed at the **Battles of Tannenberg and the Masurian Lakes**. The victorious German General Paul von Hindenburg (1837–1934) and his chief of staff General Erich Ludendorff (1883–1918) became national heroes.

On the Western Front, from September through to November, a series of battles were fought northward into Flanders (see pp.467–47). They culminated in the encounters known collectively as the **First Battle of Ypres**. With neither side able to inflict a decisive blow, the armies dug trenches along a line that was to remain broadly unchanged for three years.

Meanwhile, the war was widening into a global conflict. Ottoman Turkey joined in on the side of Germany, declaring a jihad (Muslim holy war) against the



Recruitment poster

British War Secretary Lord Kitchener's face adorned recruitment posters that called for volunteers to join up and fight.

British Empire. British troops from India landed in Turkish-ruled Iraq and seized Basra, while Japan joined the Allies and fought for control of the German concession in China. In Africa, British troops invaded German East Africa and South African forces attacked German Southwest Africa—they also put down a revolt by the Boers, who had sided with the Germans.

At Christmas, widespread fraternization between opposing troops along the Western Front appalled generals, who feared their men would lose the will to fight, but the war continued. By the end of the year around half a million French and German troops were dead, and a third of the British men who had arrived in France in August had been killed.

